ENDOCRINE ANATOMY

THE BODY'S CHEMICAL MESSENGERS, HORMONES, ARE PRODUCED BY ENDOCRINE GLANDS. HORMONES TARGET CERTAIN TISSUES TO REGULATE THEIR ACTIVITIES.

The endocrine system is composed of bodies of glandular tissue, such as the thyroid, and also includes glands within certain organs, including the testes, ovaries, and heart. These glands and tissues secrete hormones that control and coordinate body functions such as the breakdown of chemical substances in metabolism, fluid balance and urine production, growth and development, and sexual reproduction. As hormones travel in the blood, each hormone reaches every body part. However, the specific molecular shape of each hormone slots only into receptors on its target tissues or organs.